



SO YOU WANT TO START A PODCAST

Finding Your Voice, Telling Your Story,
and Building a Community That Will Listen

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The Big “So What”

Podcasts are one of the fastest-growing media as people become busier and more mobile. This is a useful guidebook to help you start your own podcast, be it for personal interest or to market your business.



Introduction

Kristen Meinzer is a successful podcast host who has reached 10 million people over 10 years of her podcasting career. She has hosted numerous shows, produced podcasts for various brands, developed shows, taught classes on audio production, and spoken at various conferences.

This book provides the motivation for you to find your voice, with specific steps to help you develop the ideas, direction, and know-how to get started. To build a successful podcast, Meinzer recommends that you supplement this book with video tutorials on the more technical aspects of podcasting.



7 Steps to Build A Successful Podcast Channel



1) Dream it: Define your Whys and Whats



Start by defining your purpose or why you want to start a podcast.

- Don't start a podcast just because everyone is doing it. Know your “why”, e.g. to build a community around a specific cause, to teach a skill, or to grow the brand for your

KEY QUOTES

“I want this book to fill you with both information and affirmation. I want it to be a toolbox you can both rely on and stand on as you share what’s in your heart.”

business. For example, *By the Book* is a show co-hosted by Meinzer and Jolenta Greenberg. In each episode, they choose a different self-help book, follow it for 2 weeks, then assess if it made a difference. Through this self-help-cum-reality-show concept, they sought to push the boundaries of podcasting and spread empowering messages in an interesting way.

- Consider if a podcast is the best method to achieve your goals. Would your “why” be more effectively achieved through a book, blog, video or social media feed?



Define who your audience is, or who your podcast is for.

- Think of your ideal listeners in such detail that they’re like real people you know and love to spend time with.
 - (i) For example, Meinzer and Greenberg wanted *By the Book* to be for self-help lovers and haters, feminists and comedy fans. These may include single mums, women of color, men listening with their wives, or misfits who want to feel less alone or insecure.
 - (ii) Meinzer and Greenberg each created 2 imaginary audience in their minds. Meinzer’s fictional listeners are Louise and Anwar—one black and one white, one gay and one straight. She knows their personalities, interests, what they do in a typical day, how they were like in high school etc. Each time she has a question (e.g. whether a joke would work or whether it’s ok to curse on the show), she’d imagine how specifically Louise and Anwar would react.



Decide on the subject/topic or what your show is about.

- Don’t settle for a 1-word answer. For example, it’s not enough to say that your show is about “movies”. Elaborate on the idea, e.g. “Each week, a movie critic interviews 1 person who has had a similar experience as a movie character.”
- Explore your concept, then distill it down to 1-3 sentences that summarize your idea and why it’s unique.
- Make it snappy and practice saying it out loud—you now have an elevator pitch to help you share your concept easily.



Creating and maintaining a podcast is hard work. So, be honest with yourself: do you really love or care about the topic or

KEY QUOTES

“Your show has to be something you can obsess over and that makes your heart sing.”

outcome enough to want to keep working on it week after week? How will the podcast fit into your life?



2) Write it: Give it Structure and Substance



Choose your podcast format. You can choose any of the common formats below, combine/vary the formats or invent your own:

- Interviews: where the host speaks with different guests each episode;
- Roundtable: where a team of 3-4 opiniated hosts discuss and debate a topic;
- Lists: where the host goes through lists such as "the worst things to eat" or 10 things to do before you die;
- Daily news;
- Advice: where the host offers advice to people who write/ call in;
- Documentaries: where the host presents a different story each episode or 1 story over several episodes;
- Investigations: where the host unravels mysteries or cases;
- Game shows: where guests play games or solve puzzles; and
- Stories: where the host narrates a short story each episode, or a long story over several episodes.



Every great show—no matter how fun or spontaneous—needs a structure or blueprint. For example, *By the Book* follows a structure like this:

Intro	Hosts play the theme song, introduce themselves and the book of the week (including a summary, the author's bio and the steps/tips they'll be following), all within 6 min
Review of Week 1	Hosts share their 1 st week of living by the book (6 min each). Followed by a music bump or ad break.
Review of Week 2	Hosts share their 2 nd week of living by the book (6 min each). Followed by a music bump or ad break.

KEY QUOTES

"The one thing that's guaranteed to kill any podcast...is a lack of love."

"Structure is something to be grateful for, not to resent."

Verdict	Hosts share their verdict on the book (3 min each).
Closing credits and easter egg (a funny/surprising outtake).	

- Once you have a rough structure, test it out using practice/pilot runs. Keep adjusting until it feels right.
- Remember: the first 5 minutes of the show is the most critical. Share just enough to acquaint new listeners to your show, then move straight into the action!



Before every show, you must prepare your script, including your research, supporting materials and notes.

- Here are some quick tips:
 - (i) For *news shows*, start with a table of contents followed by the biggest story.
 - (ii) If you're using *recorded tape or audio* collected outside the studio, let the recordings tell the story. Choose clips that best illustrate your story and work your narration around them.
 - (iii) For *stories/reality shows*, get creative and take some risks!
 - (iv) For *lessons and histories*, make sure you string the facts into engaging stories.
- Read aloud to test out the effect of the words. Inject your unique sense of humor, vocabulary, and personality.
- Ultimately, your podcast will only shine if you become a superb storyteller. Go for short, punchy sentences, and choose words that are visually-rich to bring facts to life. Fill the high points and low points of the story with visual details to touch your listeners' hearts and minds.



Once you're clear what your show is about, choose a strong title. Research what's out there and avoid a title that's already being used. Make sure the title reflects what your show is about. Keep it brief, easy to say and remember.



3) Host it: Select your Ideal Host(s)



Consider diversity when choosing your host(s) and team/guests.

KEY QUOTES

"Find the arc in each story you're telling, or create it. Play up what's exciting, and give gravity to what's serious. Make things come alive."

"Talk in stories, not facts...As much as possible, show, don't tell."

KEY QUOTES

- In the USA, where the majority of podcasts are hosted by white men, diversity can bring several benefits. It can help you to stand out, connect with more listeners, and expand your perspective.
- To recruit a diverse team, guests and experts, you can attend minority networking groups, place ads in minority newsletters or university job boards, reach out to social media communities or research experts in any domain.



Don't worry about your accent, voice or if you sound like a "professional" podcaster. Just sound like yourself—use your natural voice, laughter, figures of speech, and share your passions, opinions and sense of humor.

- Being professional isn't about imitating others. It's about being prepared for each show and producing a quality podcast.
 - (i) Prepare your materials in advance, and warm up before each show (e.g. do a few jumping jacks or sing a song).
 - (ii) Place the mic 1 fist away from your mouth (and slightly to the left/right), enunciate your words, and minimize fillers (e.g. "um", "uh" or "like"). Energize your voice by standing up, smiling and gesturing with your hands.



Consider having a co-host to add contrast, balance and diversity to the show, transform the dynamics and make it much more fun.

- Approach people whom (i) you enjoyed working with, (ii) admire, and/or (iii) have complementary skills or personality. You can do a few pilot runs with different people before making a decision.
- Your co-host is basically your partner and co-pilot.
 - (i) Agree on your respective roles/persona *on the show* (e.g. skeptic vs believer, conformist vs revolutionary) as well as *off the show* (e.g. focusing on research vs production).
 - (ii) Do your part, but learn to give and take if one person occasionally does more than the other.
- Make time to address conflict instead of avoiding it. You won't enjoy the show if you're fighting, and listeners can

"A diverse team means you're part of the solution, not the problem."

"It's your show, my friends. Make it sound like you."

"Podcasts—even the most informative of them—are entertainment, conversation, and companionship."

"Be a 'yes, and' host, not a 'no, it's all about me' host."

sense the underlying tension even if you pretend everything's ok.



4) Cast it: Get the Ideal Guests On Your Show



Identify who you want on your show in order to tell your story. There are 3 main types of guests:

- Real people help to bring specific ideas to life, e.g. individuals who're affected by a new policy or trend. You can reach out to your personal contacts, or search online for virtually *any* community (from activist groups to religious organizations and gay communities).
- Experts. If you know the experts' names and organizations, contact them through their website, social media accounts or their organizations' PR department. If you don't have a specific expert in mind, then start by researching professional clubs, associations or networking groups.
- Celebrities may be famous because they're movie-stars, award winners, or influencers on social media.
 - (i) Identify the agencies that represent them, identify yourself as a journalist, and ask for the publicist's contact. Then, email the publicist to clearly and succinctly share how their client will benefit from being on your podcast.
 - (ii) If the celebrity has recently released a book/album or appeared in a movie, ask to interview them about the project. If they're philanthropists, approach the charity's PR team and ask to discuss their latest work. You can always add other questions during the interview.
- The key is to be persistent—keep sending emails, messages, and making phone calls until you get a reply.



Once you get a positive response, start preparing your guests:

- If you definitely want the guest on your show, reply immediately to confirm the deal and give the details for the interview.

KEY QUOTES

- If you need to assess the person further, set up a 10-min phone pre-interview.
 - (i) Introduce your show (topic, tone and what to expect). Explain that this is a brief get-to-know-you session, not the actual interview.
 - (ii) Ask questions to assess if their experience/story fits with your show, if they're willing to share openly, and if their energy level is high and positive. Take notes.
 - (iii) If you decide to proceed, confirm the deal right away and send a follow-up email with the interview details. If not, thank them for their time and send a reply within 24 hours to say that you've decided to go with a different story angle.



To conduct a great interview:

- Prepare in advance. Learn what you can about your guest (e.g. background, achievements, aspirations, setbacks) and know why exactly they're on your show.
- Define the 5 most important points you want to hit, and structure your questions/conversation around them.
- Make your guest feel welcome. Let them know what to expect (e.g. "This will be a casual 5-min chat about your adventure"). Since it's a recording, they can redo a section if there's a mistake.
- Listen more, talk less. If the guest says something interesting, ask follow-up questions to invite them to share more.
- Be human and bring out their humanity. Show that they have hopes, fears, passions and failures just like the listeners.
- After the interview, thank them and follow up with an email. When the episode is out, remember to send them the link.



Meinzer recommends that you learn the entire production process first, then consider hiring a producer if you can afford it. A producer can handle almost every aspect of the show, e.g. develop story ideas, create production schedules, book and manage guests, research and write scripts, edit/publish/promote episodes, etc.



Get objective feedback so you can improve:

KEY QUOTES

"Know not just about them, but know for certain why you want to talk with them."

"Be human. Let them be human...More than anything, be you."

"Knowing all parts of the machine means you can fix any part of the machine, and it also means you can prevent certain problems from happening in the first place."

- Review your own podcast closely. Look for points when the energy drops or it feels draggy. Consider which parts went well or badly, and why.
- Ask your team members for inputs, or ask the listeners what they want more or less of.
- Join a podcast club where you can connect with other aspiring podcasters, or attend a relevant class or workshop.



5) Make it: Create Your Podcast



To get started, you just need a few key pieces of equipment in addition to your computer. These include:

- A good-enough microphone (or 2-3 mics if you have co-hosts). There's no need to spend a fortune on a top-grade microphone—you can start with just a USB mic (that can be directly plugged into your computer) and a pop shield (to reduce popping sounds).
- A set of headphones so you can listen to yourself while recording and editing.
- Recording and editing software. Beginners can start with simpler options such as Adobe Audition, Audacity or GarageBand.
- Optional: a portable audio XLR recorder that allows you to plug in 2-3 mics to record multiple tracks in separate audio files. This requires XLR microphones (not USB ones) and a memory card.
- A quiet room to do your recording. You can even do it in your closet with your clothes serving as acoustic padding.



There are several options to record the podcasts with your guests.

- Invite the guest to your home studio.
- Rent a recording studio at a mutually-convenient location.
- Go to your guest's location with your equipment.

- Do a remote interview or tape-sync, where each party records the conversation from their respective ends. You can:
 - (i) Send the guest a USB mic, ask them to plug it into their computer, record the conversation, then send you the file; or
 - (ii) Hire a local producer to go to their place (or a studio near them) with the equipment.
- Do a conference call (via Skype, Zoom etc) and record the call. Or, explore other options like Report-IT or ipDTL.
- Connect over the phone only as the last resort, since the sound quality is usually terrible.



Next, edit the audio files. The process and outcome will be better if you had recorded separate tracks for you and your guest.

- Get a transcript of the raw audio so it's easier to find the ideal moments and stitch them together.
- Focus on the big picture first. Based on what you've recorded, what story do you wish to tell? Find the sections that best tell your story, paying attention to the parts that tug at your heartstrings (vs those that put you to sleep).
- With the end in mind, start cutting and editing the tape.
 - (i) Never present your guests' words out of context or edit them to mean a different thing.
 - (ii) Remove the rambling, coughs/sneezes, or unexpected noises.
 - (iii) Remove most of the fillers (e.g. "ums") but not to the point it sounds unnatural. Fillers can even be useful for connecting 2 disjointed parts.
 - (iv) Avoid abrupt changes to tempo, tone, volume, or loud/long stretches of music. Keep any theme song to <30s.
- As you edit, identify areas to improve for future recordings, and have fun in the process!

"Do what you can to make them sound like the truest version of themselves."



Other important considerations include:

- Intellectual property rights. As a rule of thumb, go for *podsafe* (royalty-free) music/movie clips and written material. Official

movie clips and trailers are safe for the purposes of movie reviews or discussions, though you can contact the TV or movie press-reps for *electronic press kits*. Always credit the creator/author and consult an attorney if in doubt.

- Podcast length. Ideally, keep your podcasts to 20-40 minutes. Meinzer recommends starting with a shorter show of ≈20min as it's easier to manage and you'll be forced to make every second count. You can always extend the duration in future.
- Know what all listeners love or hate.
 - (i) Listeners love solid takeaways (e.g. clear insights and conclusions), hosts who're willing to reveal their personal and vulnerable side, and predictability with some surprises (e.g. a standard structure with occasional twists).
 - (ii) Listeners hate poor sound quality (e.g. noisy background), overproduced audio (with too much special effects), inconsistency (in schedule, tone or structure) and a lack of empathy for listeners.



6) Share it: Distribute your Podcast



Create your release schedule.

- Be consistent with your podcast releases so listeners know exactly which day/time to expect your show. Generally, it's fine to do a release *every 1-2 weeks*. Don't be too ambitious (e.g. daily releases) or too infrequent (e.g. monthly releases).
- Communicate your schedule clearly:
 - (i) If it's an ongoing series, remind listeners that you'll be back at the same time/day next week.
 - (ii) If it's a seasonal show (e.g. 1-2 seasons per year), indicate when the next season will start.
 - (iii) If it's a short-run series (i.e. a limited number of episodes), thank listeners for joining you for that duration.



Make your podcast stand out.

KEY QUOTES

"Make sure that every word must be."

"[Listeners] want their hosts to be human, not perfect."

- Create an attractive show art. This will be just a tiny square on a small screen. So, keep it simple and make sure the words are clear and legible. Decide on your color palette and image, then use the same style across all your marketing messages.
- Make sure your episode titles and descriptions are catchy.
 - (i) Finalize the *episode title* only after you've edited the episode. Focus on what's interesting e.g. "Ariana Grande on her saddest childhood memory." Number your episodes if they run in sequence, e.g. "Ep. 1: ABC", "Ep. 2: XYZ".
 - (ii) Keep the *episode descriptions* succinct. Include a hook that highlights the story you'll be telling, names of notable persons, events or places, contact information, links and advertiser acknowledgements.



Distribute your podcast in 4 steps:

- Save your episode in the right format (typically mp3);
- Choose your hosting platform. You can use a podcast-friendly hosting option (e.g. Libsyn, SoundCloud) or your own blog (e.g. Wordpress, Wix, Squarespace).
- Set up your feed. An RSS feed is basically a list of your episodes with key metadata (e.g. title, author, description, cover art, categories, and duration).
- Send your podcast/feed to as many places as possible (e.g. Google Podcasts, Apple Podcasts, Spotify)—a process called syndication. When you update your RSS feed in future, all the stores you're registered with will be automatically updated.



Sadly, most podcasts don't make money. To get listeners to pay, they must first feel engaged and invested in your show. To attract advertisers, you probably need ≥ 5000 listeners per episode. Here are some monetization options to explore:

- Donations from your listeners in return for gifts, shout-outs or other rewards;
- Paid membership or subscriptions, e.g. offering perks like ad-free listening or bonus content for a few extra dollars each month;

- Advertising: Look for advertisers who're open to smaller shows and want to reach your specific audience. For example, a show about motherhood is ideal for companies selling baby food or diapers; and
- Sponsored content: This is where advertisers pay for their products to be a central part of your story. However, this could mean a longer production process and some loss of control over your storyline.



7) Grow it: Promote your Podcast



It's not enough to create a great podcast. You must promote your show if you want more people to discover and enjoy it. One of the best ways to spread the word is to build a community.

- In every episode, create engagement within the show:
 - (i) Mention how people can reach you and why they should write/call. You can set the phone number to go to voicemail for people to leave a message.
 - (ii) Invite listeners to share their experiences for a specific topic, let them contact you for advice or to offer advice.
 - (iii) Add assignments, e.g. get listeners to answer questions or solve a puzzle, then selectively acknowledge the participants.
 - (iv) Ask listeners questions that lead to new stories, e.g. their most embarrassing incident, their first love.
- You can also build engagement outside the show:
 - (i) Create a space (e.g. a Facebook community) where listeners can interact with one another.
 - (ii) Use social media or your website to share glimpses of your personal life, what you're reading or thinking about, etc.
 - (iii) Create opportunities for people to meet you in person, e.g. via live shows and meetups.
- Encourage your community to bring others onboard:

"The onus is on you to get the word out—every week, for several hours a week."

- (i) In every episode, ask listeners to rate/review your podcast. Occasionally read out the reviews and thank your listeners.
- (ii) End every interaction with a reminder to spread the word, e.g. "Thank you so much for following the show and for spreading the word to all your friends and family!"

 Here are 7 additional ways to get the word out:

- Tell everyone about your show: share your elevator pitch with links to your show.
- Create a web-page so people can find you.
- Use guerrilla marketing, e.g. jump onto podcast discussions (on Reddit, Twitter etc.), and say something provocative so people will respond and learn about your podcast.
- Do promo swaps with other hosts with a similar audience size and profile. Or, pitch yourself as a guest for these shows. When you're being interviewed, don't just answer the questions directly. Steer the conversation to what you wish to say. Imagine that your show is about macho men with a sensitive side, and the other host is asking a question about rugby. You can pivot the discussion by saying, "Interestingly, rugby is seen as one of the most "macho" sports. The macho men on my show..."
- After each interview, send the guests a thank you note with a link to the episode and a request to share the link. Tag them in your social media posts (along with a great quote from the show) so they're more likely to share/retweet the post.

 When you receive harsh criticisms or mean comments, don't take it personally. Try to sieve out the constructive feedback from the insults, and see it as an opportunity to create engagement and publicity. By acknowledging and addressing your shortfalls, you can win your listeners' loyalty.

 Embrace your identity as a podcaster. Use the title in your name cards, say the title out loud and immerse yourself in the world of podcasting to build your knowledge and contacts. For example, you can (i) subscribe to podcasting newsletters and publications, (ii) join podcasting communities and weigh in on the discussions, (iii) attend conferences about podcasting,

"Say what you want, not what you're asked."

"Turn all your thank-yous into self-promotions."

"Embrace your voice! Share it with the world!"

(iv) reach out to people you admire, and (v) take classes and courses.

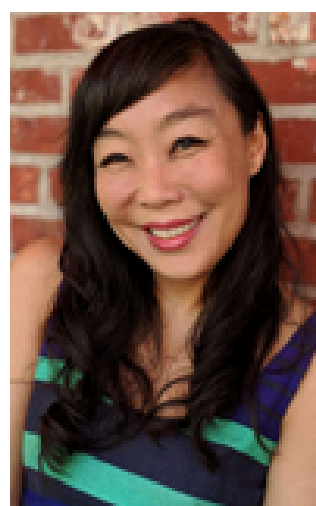
KEY QUOTES

Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This is a fun, lively book written in short and easy to read chapters. Besides the tips captured in this summary, the book also includes useful information such as podcast statistics, sample email pitches and confirmation emails for guests. For more information, please visit www.kristenmeinzer.com

About the Author

Kristen Meinzer is a podcast host, producer, and former director of nonfiction programming for Panoply. Her hosting credits include Stitcher/Panoply's By the Book, CNN's Decades of Movies, and WNYC/PRI's Movie Date. Her producing credits include Happier with Gretchen Rubin, The Sporkful, Food 52's Burnt Toast, Girlboss Radio, and other award-winning shows. Kristen's work has been mentioned in numerous publications including Time, Washington Post, BuzzFeed, and Indiewire.



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